ROOFTOP TOMATOES

Written by

The Panelwise team

Self-written sample screenplay for Panelwise.
Licence: Apache-2.0, the same as the repository.

FADE IN:

1 EXT. BLOCK OF FLATS - ROOF - DAY 1

A concrete roof twelve storeys up in Hillbrow. Satellite dishes, a water tank, a broken plastic chair. The whole city spreads out below.

MRS. ABRAHAMS (70s), sun hat, gardening gloves, drags a paint tin full of soil across the roof. She has made a row of them, each with a small green seedling.

2 INT. BLOCK OF FLATS - LIFT - DAY 2

A cramped lift with a mirror covered in stickers. LWAZI (17), headphones around his neck, holds a skateboard. The lift shudders and stops. The doors stay closed.

LWAZI
Not again.

He presses the button for the roof. The lift jerks upward.

3 EXT. BLOCK OF FLATS - ROOF - CONTINUOUS 3

The roof door bangs open. Lwazi steps out with his skateboard and stops. Mrs. Abrahams points a watering can at him.

MRS. ABRAHAMS
Mind my tomatoes.

LWAZI
You can't grow tomatoes up here. There's no ground.

MRS. ABRAHAMS
There's soil. There's sun. There's me. That's three things more than most gardens have.

LWAZI
This is where I skate.

MRS. ABRAHAMS
(pointing)
Then skate there. That side. This side is for tomatoes.

She goes back to watering. Lwazi rolls his eyes and pushes off along the far edge.

4 EXT. BLOCK OF FLATS - ROOF - MORNING 4

Weeks have passed. The seedlings are taller, tied to sticks. Lwazi sits on the broken chair, skateboard across his knees, eating chips from a packet.

Mrs. Abrahams kneels by a plant, frowning at a leaf.

MRS. ABRAHAMS
Something is eating them.

LWAZI
Not me.

MRS. ABRAHAMS
I didn't say you.

A PIGEON lands on a paint tin and pecks at a leaf.

LWAZI
(getting up)
That one.

He flaps his arms. The pigeon flies off. Mrs. Abrahams looks at him for a long moment.

MRS. ABRAHAMS
You can stay. If you're on pigeon duty.

5 EXT. BLOCK OF FLATS - ROOF - NIGHT 5

A storm. Rain hammers the concrete. Lightning over the city.

Lwazi bursts through the roof door with a roll of plastic sheeting. He is soaked at once.

LWAZI
(shouting over the rain)
Mrs. Abrahams! Mrs. Abrahams, the plants!

Nobody answers. He looks at the row of tins, bent flat in the wind.

He drags the broken chair, the skateboard, two bricks, and pins the plastic sheet over the tomatoes.

6 INT. BLOCK OF FLATS - MRS. ABRAHAMS'S FLAT - NIGHT 6

A tidy flat full of photographs. Mrs. Abrahams sits in an armchair, one ankle wrapped in a bandage, resting on a stool. She watches the rain at the window.

There's a knock. She hobbles to the door. Lwazi stands there, dripping.

LWAZI
They're covered. All of them.

MRS. ABRAHAMS
(quietly)
Come in before you drown.

7 EXT. BLOCK OF FLATS - ROOF - DAY 7

Bright sun. The plastic sheet is folded on the chair. Every plant hangs heavy with red TOMATOES.

Lwazi picks one and holds it up to the sky. Mrs. Abrahams, on a walking stick, nods.

MRS. ABRAHAMS
Now. Who taught you to skate?

LWAZI
Nobody. YouTube.

MRS. ABRAHAMS
Then today I'll teach you to make tomato bredie, and you'll teach me to skate.

LWAZI
You'll break your other ankle.

MRS. ABRAHAMS
(holding out her hand for the board)
Then you'll carry me down the stairs.

FADE OUT.